

Fasting Enforces the Position of Death

Matthew 17 Shows a Ceiling the Disciples Did Not Know They Had

Go to an old friend, Romans 8. We will begin around verse 8. The only other chapter we may turn to is Romans 6.

We began this teaching from Matthew 17. Jesus came down from the Mount of Transfiguration with Peter, James, and John. While He was there, His face shone like the sun, and His clothing was white as light. The three disciples were beside themselves.

When they came down, they found a commotion at the base of the mountain. The other nine disciples had been trying to cast a devil out of a boy. They had cast devils out before, but for some reason they could not get this one to come out. Their trying had drawn a crowd.

The father threw himself down and said, "I brought him to Your disciples, and they could not cast him out."

Jesus said:

O faithless and perverse generation, how long shall I be with you? how long shall I suffer you?

In other words, "How long am I going to have to do this for you?"

Why would He say that if He did not fully intend for us to do it? Then He said, "Bring the child to Me." He rebuked the devil, cast it out, and it left from that hour.

Later the disciples got Him privately and asked, "Why could we not cast it out?" I would have done the same thing. I would not have yelled over the crowd, "Why could I not cast it out?" and had Him yell back, "Because of your unbelief."

Jesus told them plainly:

Because of your unbelief.

Then He said:

If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you.

For a long time I missed what was in this chapter. When I finally understood that unbelief was the reason the devil would not come out, it dawned on me that fasting had something to do with unbelief.

This is a very subtle, very deceptive kind of unbelief. It puts a ceiling on your life until one year is like the next. Sometimes we attain to anointings and get to a certain place, then nothing changes. Decades can turn into generations, and generations into centuries, until we stand before Jesus with not even a third of what we could have had.

The disciples did not know they had this unbelief. They had been casting devils out. If they had known, they would not have asked Jesus why the devil did not come out.

This Kind Refers to Unbelief, Not Only a Class of Demon

Many preachers equate fasting only with deliverance ministries. Jesus did not say that. He said, "You see that mountain? You could say to that mountain, remove hence to yonder place, and it would obey you." The stipulation was dealing with this particular kind of unbelief.

Then He said:

Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting.

Because of the order of the verses, many preachers say, "I am a teacher, pastor, or government gift. I am not called to deliverance, so why should I fast?"

Let me tell you something about the reward system. When we get to heaven, what we are known for forever is not limited to "the mighty apostle" or "the mighty prophet." His reward works according to your calling. If you took all you had and did all He told you, you receive all the reward He has for that calling.

The primary reason that devil would not come out was unbelief. If unbelief is the problem, then fasting has something to do with unbelief.

We understand what prayer has to do with unbelief. Edification comes from praying in the Holy Ghost. The presence of God comes into temporary situations through worship. We can change things by speaking His Word.

The hard thing to understand is what fasting has to do with unbelief. What does going without eating have to do with anything?

Impossible Need Exposes the Ceiling We Have Accepted

Here is the illustration I gave Sunday. Suppose ten children under five years old were brought in, all in wheelchairs, all imprisoned in bodies that would not work.

You know how active a child's spirit is. Those little bodies are usually so full of energy that at a change of thought they run back and forth picking up toys. I cannot fathom a little spirit in prison, unable to do that.

Some of their worlds are dark. Some are dark with no hearing. Some are twisted. Some are sharp intellectually, but their senses are gone, their bodies shut down, and they cannot communicate with this world.

If I were born like that, I would want to be born into a family who knew they were sons and knew their rights, so they could go get my miracle for me. Do not just leave me there year after year. Face it and get it for me.

Most of us are content to fill the church with them every Sunday and see them go home the same way year after year. Yet in our language, we say we have a covenant. We have more than a covenant; that covenant delivered us to sonship.

If I prayed for them all and nothing happened, and Jesus came in with His glorified body, I know He would not give me a different answer than He gave His disciples. He would go over, empty all the wheelchairs, come back, and I would say, "That was my question. Why did You do that when I prayed?"

He would say, "Mr. Roberson, it is not that I did not want to. What did I do when I got here? I healed them."

"Then why did You not do it when I touched them?"

He would answer, "Because of your unbelief."

I might say, "But Jesus, I milked every fiber of my being. I reached inside and turned every cell inside out."

Nevertheless, He would stand firm.

The next question is, what do I do about it? He says, "If you had faith as a grain of mustard seed, you could speak to this mountain. Deal with this, and absolutely nothing shall be impossible to you."

Romans 8 Declares the Body Dead Because the Spirit Has Life

I found my answer in an unusual place. Romans 8:10 says:

And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin; but the Spirit is life because of righteousness.

If Christ is in you, you qualify for the rest of that verse. You are existing in this state: the body is dead because of sin, but the spirit is life because of righteousness.

What Paul is saying is that because your spirit has come alive with His new nature, that new nature supplies enough life to bring life to your flesh so your flesh cannot dominate your spirit with sin or unbelief.

Romans 8:23 eventually deals with our natural bodies:

And not only they, but ourselves also, which have the firstfruits of the Spirit... groan within ourselves, waiting for the adoption, to wit, the redemption of our body.

We have the firstfruits of the Spirit. That is the new nature in our spirit because Christ is in us. We groan within ourselves out of that new nature, waiting for the adoption process to be made complete at the redemption of our bodies.

We are here on this earth in a body still capable of things our spirit does not want to do. The soul can worry. The body can sin. The new nature cries for righteousness and for the whole lump to be leavened: spirit, soul, and body.

We see wars, starving children, sick children, and the results of the curse living next door. Our righteous spirits groan for the adoption process to be made complete, when the suffering stops.

Meanwhile, if Christ is in you, sin's ability to dominate your soul and flesh has been taken by your spirit. The body is dead because of sin, and the spirit is life because of righteousness.

Fasting Enforces a Position That Only the Born-Again Have

The moment I was born again, my spirit entered into life. Sin lost its dominion over me because my old man was crucified with Christ and the man of sin was destroyed.

That position my spirit took says that as far as my flesh is concerned, it might as well be dead because it does not have power to reign over me anymore.

That is why fasting did Mahatma Gandhi no spiritual good. That is why it did Buddha no good. They did not have righteous spirits. There was no position for their bodies to be put into through fasting. There was no position to render the body dead by. When they fasted, they just got hungry.

Not you. A position has been afforded your flesh to be enforced: dead.

The new nature of your righteous spirit says, "Flesh, you do not have more power than I have." When you fast, you enforce the position of death your flesh received when your spirit was born again.

As faith people, we understand our position in Christ. I am from above and not below. I am a son of God. I am seated in heavenly places with Christ Jesus. We understand the position declared over our spirit.

What we have not understood is the position our spirit has been given over our flesh: it is dead.

That is why we have missed the power and reason for fasting. We thought fasting moved God. It does not. Isaiah 58 says fasting will not make your voice heard on high, but it will help you hear His voice down low.

Fasting does not make you more righteous than you were. It does not give your spirit more standing than it already had when it was freed from sin. Nothing you can do can earn a position that cannot be earned. But these keys can enforce the grace already given to you in Christ Jesus.

Fasting Drops the Flesh Below the Spirit's Operation

Fasting does not move God. It moves you into a place to receive what He is already doing.

Many times the operation of the flesh ceilings the operation of the new creation inside you. Your spirit is pregnant with God's nature, but flesh keeps bouncing against it.

Then someone preaches on fasting and says you can move God with your fasting. You start fasting, praying in the Holy Ghost, worshiping, and confessing His Word. Your spirit rises in position. While you add fasting, the dominance and ceiling of the flesh begins losing ground.

Fast, pray, fast, pray, until the dominance of the flesh drops below the ceiling of your spirit.

Then the flesh wrestles back and says, "I am back on top again." So keep fasting and praying until it drops down below. Suddenly, the answer to prayer begins to flow.

Why? Not because you moved God, but because the ceiling on your life caused by the flesh dropped below the operation of the spirit.

People get discouraged because they hear that the prophet's fast is a forty-day fast and that many men of God who accomplished those fasts had lives earmarked with power. Usually they do enter into deliverance ministry, because devils cry when they come into their presence.

But fasting is nothing to brag about. When I see a ministry of absolute power that did it without much fasting, I want to wash their feet. They took the rebirth and walking in the Spirit and did so much.

I am actually ashamed to have had to fast as much as I have, because if my flesh had that much hold on me, I am ashamed it took those lengths to break.

Fasting Exposes What God Wants You to Hate

On my first longer fast, everything was great. I went to a camp meeting, the power was there, and I was freer and full of joy.

On my second longer fast, God got me under a magnifying glass. I went into intercession. He brought me into an examination of the things He did not like about me. I felt hopeless standing in it, and that produced intercession. When you hate a problem as much as God does, you are releasing faith He can use to destroy it.

As long as you tolerate, love, embrace, and walk with it, what does He have to work with?

Isaiah 58 says this is the fast He has chosen: to loose the bands of wickedness, to bring the naked into your house, to feed the poor, and to hide not yourself from your own flesh.

The day you decide to fast is the day you decide not to hide from the things stopping you anymore. If God has to get them out where you hate them as much as He does, so be it.

When He showed me ugly things He did not like about me, He displaced and replaced them with peace. It must be His love, because it freed me from torment and fear.

Perfect love casts out fear. That includes more than fear over budgets or ministry pressures. Sometimes someone close to you gets ugly, and you react wrong because their ugliness taps something in you that should not be there. You are no longer operating for their best; you are operating in your own survival.

The love called agape frees you from that torment so you can minister to them as the Lord Jesus Christ would have you do.

Do Not Quit Because One Fast Only Revealed the Problem

When I came out of that second fast, I went to my next camp meeting, and there was virtually no power on me. I had seen people fall out in groves before. Then I walked out and everyone just stood there like an iron on the board when I touched them.

I panicked. Pride, self-exaltation, everything was on the line. I had to fight not to discard fasting. I thought, "Maybe they are right. Maybe three days is sufficient."

Some say praying too much in tongues opens you up to the devil. Sure it does. The devil notices what you are doing and says you need to be stopped. Otherwise, just make your little journey and see what you get at the end.

They say you can fast too much and get strange. You can fast foolishly. That is different from praying in tongues; you cannot pray too much in tongues because the Holy Ghost has taken the understanding of the gift away from you and is praying for what you need. You may think you need a Cadillac; He may think you need to quit yelling at your wife.

I almost adopted the popular teaching on fasting, but I bit my tongue and held on. I went into another fast, made it only halfway through, and that is when the peace came.

That is why we teach series fasting. Fast three days, eat two, fast three, eat two. It can be just as effective as long fasting, especially for people with jobs or strenuous labor. Eventually, it can accomplish the same result.

Every week you keep destroying the unbelief you are walking in, until the flesh drops below the operation of the spirit and the things begin to flow.

The Fast Chosen by God Refuses to Hide From the Flesh

Isaiah 58 says that you hide not yourself from your own flesh. When God showed me things He did not like about me, I liked them even less.

I am not a martyr. I am not running around moping in a corner. I have more peace than I ever had. I hear His voice like I never heard Him. I have a mandate. When I preach on mortification, it is mostly on the level of people needing to be free from torment and disease, but there is another level: getting things behind you so you can help other people.

A man from another country once sat through a series I taught on fasting. He had just completed a major fast, what you would qualify as a prophet's fast. He and his wife were having terrible trouble. After the fast, he hated himself, hated everything, and did not understand it. He got rid of his wife, divorced her, and picked up one from an Eastern Bloc country because, as he said, "She will be more obedient."

After I preached, he came to me and said, "Do you mean all that unrighteousness I felt at the end of my fast was things coming out of me?"

I said, "That is right. What made your wife any different at the end of the fast than she was before you entered it? She remained the same. You are the one who changed. You hated what was in you and blamed her."

He said, "Oh my God. What do I do?"

I said, "Now that you hate what is in you so much, why do you not finish? You have faith to die now. You have faith to move it out of your life. You are looking at it through God's eyes. When you loved it, what did He have to work with?"

The Aim Is Flesh Below the Level Revival Requires

What am I after now? I do not care about faith for things anymore, not my things as priority. I have Him. I have everything. I like things, and I am not strange, but they have to be sanctified.

Anything you can get in the natural world, you cannot necessarily get in the spirit.

What do I want? I want my flesh to drop below the level those ten children need it to drop below. I want my flesh to drop below the level revival needs it to drop below. I want my flesh to drop below the level where I can believe for millions of sets of *The Walk of the Spirit* videos in Indian dialects, so we can send every preacher home with a study course.

It does not matter where he is, in a village, with nobody around him. He can begin his journey into everything Jesus said he could be.

I want the reward. That is what I want. And because it is available, I will get it.

Now that I know how much of Him can be had, I know where my journey is going. I have everything. I have Jesus to show me the way.

Stand up. I do not want to overload you.